



DRESS for

Animals come in many colors. Some are drab, some are patterned, and some are every color of the rainbow. But there are many reasons why animals have evolved such a variety of colors...

It all comes down to one thing—*survival of the species*.

ONE OF THE GANG

Color helps animals recognize others of the same species. Not all animals can see in color—some see only patterns of light and shade.

Others can see all or parts of the visible spectrum and sometimes infrared or ultraviolet. Animals with the best color vision are often very colorful themselves.

NOW YOU
SEE ME...

... NOW
YOU
DON'T

Hey, where did
my lunch go?

Blend in

The ability to blend into the background is a distinct advantage. For predators, being able to sneak up on your prey without being seen means you are much more likely to get your dinner. For prey animals, being hard to see ensures you don't become the target.



Spots and stripes are used by animals that live in forests or long grass to help break up the outline of the animal.

Lions only see in shades of gray.

One of the best ways to *hide* yourself is to look like *something else*,

?
Stick
or...



STICK INSECT

?
... *leaf*
or...



LEAF INSECT

?
... *thorn*
or...



THORN BUG

Disguising yourself to look like something else is called mimicry. Many animals have evolved to look like dead leaves, twigs, seaweed, or even bird droppings. Predators are fooled into thinking it's not something they're interested in or that

it's something they should avoid. Birds won't eat hoverflies because they look like wasps, which will sting if eaten. However, the flower mantis not only uses its appearance to hide, but also to attract its insect prey. Plants use mimicry, too.